

Unacknowledged: Lesson 1

Who Makes History?

Lesson objectives:

- Identify characteristics that make people or events remembered in history.
- Recognize that many influential figures are overlooked or unacknowledged.
- Describe initial impressions of Mansa Musa and generate questions about his legacy.
- Reflect on who decides what becomes “history.”

Assessment:

- Completed Worksheet
- Exit Ticket

Key Points:

- Students begin exploring the idea that not all stories make it into the spotlight. Through a lively activity and short exploration, they’ll question how “fame,” “influence,” and “importance” are decided — and meet one figure history often overlooks: Mansa Musa.
- Students begin by brainstorming who makes it into history and why, through an engaging “History Hall of Fame” activity.
- Students watch an introductory video on Mansa Musa to spark curiosity about why his story is lesser known.
- Students discuss how power, perspective, and visibility shape who is remembered.
- Students read a short adapted article introducing Mansa Musa and consider how sources shape what we learn about the past.

Component:	Teacher & Student Actions	Materials
Do Now	• Do Now: Imagine there’s a “Hall of Fame for History.”	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Introduction of Unacknowledged	Introduce unit expectations, assignments, and schedule	Slides
Guided Practice	History Hall of Fame • Using the answers from students’ Do Now, the class will develop a list of figures who they think should go in a hall of fame • Discussion Questions to consider:	Slides

	○ What do you notice about who made our list? ○ Are there groups, regions, or people missing? ○ Why might some stories rise to the top — and others fade away?	
Mini-Lesson	● Watch a short video: The Richest Man You Never Heard Of ● Students will share their reactions to the video by finger voting ● Teacher will review what's been learned about Mansa Musa	Slides Video
Partner Practice	Think-Pair-Share: ● Students will consider two questions ○ Why might someone as powerful as Mansa Musa be overlooked in history books? ○ What might cause a story to be remembered — or forgotten? ● Discuss with a partner, and ● Share out as a class	Handouts
Closing	● Exit Ticket: Finish one of the sentences below: ○ "Mansa Musa should be remembered because ..." ○ "History often overlooks ..." ○ "I wonder ..."	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Differentiation Considerations:		
● Teacher can model examples for the "History Hall of Fame" to support idea generation. ● Students can work in pairs or small groups during discussions to lower participation barriers. ● Sentence stems (e.g., "I think ___ should be remembered because ___") can help scaffold verbal or written responses. ● The video can be played with captions, and questions can be projected visually. ● Exit ticket can be completed verbally or in writing.		

Standard(s):

- CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RH.6-8.2 – Determine the central ideas or information of a primary or secondary source.
- CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.SL.8.1 – Engage effectively in collaborative discussions on grade-level topics.
- D2.His.2.6-8 (C3 Framework) – Classify series of historical events and developments as examples of change and/or continuity.

Unacknowledged: Lesson 2

The Lion of Mali

Lesson objectives:		
- Describe Mansa Musa's leadership and accomplishments. - Identify how his story has been told in modern media and writing. - Create an original headline that reflects perspective and emphasis. - Reflect on how storytelling shapes historical legacy.		
Assessment:		
- Handout - Exit Ticket		
Key Points:		
- Students read and analyze a short informational text about Mansa Musa's reign and achievements. - Students identify key details about Mali's wealth, geography, and cultural influence. - Through a "Headline Creator" activity, students summarize Mansa Musa's legacy and interpret how different perspectives might portray him. - Students reflect on why his story has been overlooked, using evidence from the reading and class discussion.		
Component:	Teacher & Student Actions	Materials
Do Now	- Do Now: Think of a modern public figure who has power or influence. - What makes them powerful? - How will people remember them 100 years from now?	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Mini-Lesson	- Read: The Forgotten Emperor - Discussion - What factors contributed to Mansa Musa's immense wealth during his reign as emperor of Mali? - How did his hajj impact perceptions of his empire in Europe and the Middle East? - Can we trust what we just read - Students will consider the sources cited in their reading and determine if the reading was credible	Slides Handouts

	• From Wakanda to History: Students will look for connections between current representations of fictional places and Africa • Mali Then and Now	
Independent Practice	• Students will create a headline to represent Mansa Musa in history	Handouts
Closing	• Exit Ticket: Mansa Musa changed the world – but many people still don't know his name. ○ What do you think makes a story get overlooked? ○ What part of his story do you want to learn more about next?	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Differentiation Considerations:		
• Teacher may assign parts of the reading for guided or choral reading to support literacy needs. • Provide a vocabulary preview (e.g., “pilgrimage,” “empire,” “trade routes”). • Sentence frames can support headline writing (e.g., “Mansa Musa: The ___ Who ___”). • Students can highlight key points in the reading instead of taking notes. • Offer printed or digital versions of the article depending on accessibility needs.		
Standard(s):		
• CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RH.6-8.6 – Identify aspects of a text that reveal an author’s point of view or purpose. • D2.His.4.6-8 – Analyze multiple factors that influenced perspectives of people during different historical eras. • D2.Civ.2.6-8 – Explain how political, economic, and social contexts shape viewpoints.		

Unacknowledged: Lesson 3

Whose Story Gets Told?

Lesson objectives:

- Describe what the Catalan Atlas shows about Mansa Musa and the Mali Empire.
- Explain who created the map and why it matters.
- Identify evidence of perspective or bias in a historical source.
- Reflect on how representation can shape how people are remembered.

Assessment:

- Exit Ticket
- Handout

Key Points:

- Students investigate the Catalan Atlas as a primary source that shaped how the world saw Mansa Musa.
- In small groups (or individually), students analyze different sections of the map, noting what is emphasized or missing.
- Each group shares findings, building a class understanding of how perspective and bias influence historical records.
- Students watch a short video to connect the map to broader ideas about how history is visualized and remembered.

Component:	Teacher & Student Actions	Materials
Do Now	• Do Now: Memory Draw - Without using any words, draw a quick picture that shows something important about you – a memory, a goal, or something you're proud of.	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Mini-Lesson	• Students will be introduced to the Catalan Atlas • Optional video: Mansa Musa and the Catalan Atlas	Slides
Guided Practice	• Group investigation into the Catalan Atlas. Three images of the Catalan Atlas (panel III) will be distributed. Students will complete the worksheet while reviewing one of the	Slides Handouts

	images. After, the class will come together and discuss all three images. - NOTE: This activity can be done in groups where a group of students reviews one of the images and completes their handouts together before coming together as a class and each group reports out; OR the activity can be done individually, where each student receives one of the images and completes the handout independently before coming together as a class and discussing. - Lightning Round Synthesis: For each slide with a question, students will be given ~15 seconds to consider the question, then teacher will randomly call on two students to answer the question using the sentence starter. (Approx 1 min per slide/question)	
Independent Practice	Put him back on the map: Students will use their handout to create their own illustrated map representing Mansa Musa	Slides Handouts
Closing	Exit Ticket: Respond to the questions: What does it mean to 'put someone on the map'? How can art, writing, or media help people be remembered?"	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Differentiation Considerations:		
- Offer guiding questions on handouts to scaffold analysis ("What do you notice?" "What might this symbol mean?"). - Students can work in mixed-ability pairs for the investigation. - Teacher may project the map and annotate with student responses for visual learners. - Use the "Lightning Round" to give all students a chance to participate quickly.		
Standard(s):		
- CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RH.6-8.7 – Integrate visual information with other information in print and digital texts. - D2.His.6.6-8 – Analyze how people's perspectives influenced what information was recorded and remembered.		

- CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.SL.8.1.C – Pose and respond to questions that connect ideas and elaborate on others' comments.

Unacknowledged: Lesson 4

Seeing and Being Seen

Lesson objectives:

- Define bias and perspective in historical storytelling.
- Identify examples of historical figures who have been overlooked or misrepresented.
- Compare Mansa Musa's story to another "unacknowledged" figure (like Sacagawea or Claudette Colvin).
- Reflect on why representation and acknowledgment matter in shaping collective memory.

Assessment:

- Handout
- Exit Ticket

Key Points:

- Students learn about bias and perspective through clear, relatable examples before applying these ideas to history.
- In a gallery-walk style "Case Study Carousel," students examine the lives of overlooked or unacknowledged historical figures.
- Students record notes and discuss common patterns across the stories – who is remembered, who isn't, and why.
- A class synthesis activity helps students link these case studies back to Mansa Musa's story and the unit theme.

Component:	Teacher & Student Actions	Materials
Do Now	• Do Now: What's the first thing you notice? ○ What do you assume about each person based on the image? ○ Where do those assumptions come from?	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Mini-Lesson	• Bias & Perspective: Students will define the terms and start to put together that all historical sources contain both	Slides
Independent Practice	• Case Study Carousel: Students will consider several historical figures who have mostly gone unacknowledged and come to understand why that is. • NOTE: This activity can be done in several ways	Slides

	○ Gallery Walk: the profiles of the nine historical figures can be posted on the walls around the room and students can move from one to the next, completing their handout ○ Stations: Students can be grouped in stations and pass the profiles from one station to the next, completing their handout. ○ As a class on the board: if there is limited ability for classroom movement, the profile slides can be shown on the board to all students as they complete their handout ● NOTE: Teachers are encouraged to add or swap out other historical figures that may be of interest or relevant to their students	
Guided Practice	● Class debrief discussion ● Question to consider: Is acknowledging someone a form of power?	Slides
Closing	● Exit Ticket: Do you think Cornelia's work should be considered science? Why or why not?	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Differentiation Considerations:		
● Provide summaries or simplified profiles for selected historical figures. ● Offer multiple ways to complete the carousel (gallery walk, station work, or whole-class projection). ● Allow verbal or visual responses for students who prefer drawing or listing over writing. ● Use sentence stems such as "This person reminds me of Mansa Musa because..." to prompt connections. ● Extend learning for advanced students by having them research a modern "unacknowledged" figure.		
Standard(s):		
● D2.His.6.6-8 – Analyze how people's perspectives shaped historical narratives. ● CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RH.6-8.9 – Analyze the relationship between a primary and secondary source on the same topic. ● D2.Civ.10.6-8 – Explain the impact of civic participation and recognition in communities.		

Unacknowledged: Lesson 5

Crafting Your “Unacknowledged Map”

Lesson objectives:		
- Identify key elements that make a story visible and memorable. - Plan and design an illustrated map that expresses their identity, values, and vision. - Explain the symbolism, geography, and message behind their map using evidence and reflection. - Apply clear design and writing criteria to prepare a final product for submission.		
Assessment:		
- Handout - Exit Ticket		
Key Points:		
- Students learn what illustrated maps are and review example maps that blend place and personal meaning. - Students brainstorm how they, their community, or their chosen subject should be remembered in history. - Using a guided four-part worksheet, students plan and begin sketching their illustrated maps. - Students participate in a structured peer feedback session, testing whether their maps communicate the intended story and message.		
Component:	Teacher & Student Actions	Materials
Do Now	Do Now: If you could create a map that showed your life, your journey, or your community, what landmarks would appear—and why?	Slides Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Mini-Lesson	Introduction to illustrated maps: a creative map that shows ideas, experiences, or emotions instead of just geography.	Slides
Guided Practice	- Review of Building Your Map Plan - Choose your focus (myself, my community, or someone I don't want to be forgotten) - How Should It Be Remembered? - Brainstorm Location & Landmarks - Design Symbols	Slides Handouts Pencils, paper, colored pencils

	○ Add Meaning with a Mapmakers Statement ● Review maps for inspiration	
Independent Practice	● Students complete their map building plan and make a draft of their map	Handouts Pencils, paper, colored pencils
Partner Feedback	● Students swap their map with a partner and provide feedback for improving their designs	
Closing	● Exit Ticket: The message I want my map to leave behind is ____.	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Differentiation Considerations:		
● Offer printed and digital templates for the map outline. ● Provide step-by-step checklists for pacing support. ● Allow for verbal explanation of map ideas before writing. ● Sentence frames can guide the statement writing (e.g., "My map shows that..." "This place matters because..."). ● Provide model examples and optional stencils for students who need visual structure.		
Standard(s):		
● D2.His.12.6-8 – Use questions to establish the significance of historical events or people. ● CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.WHST.6-8.4 – Produce clear and coherent writing appropriate to task, purpose, and audience. ● D2.Civ.10.6-8 – Explain how artistic and civic expression can influence shared memory.		

Unacknowledged: Lesson(s) 6+

Finalizing Your “Unacknowledged Map”

Lesson objectives:		
Finalize student unacknowledged maps		
Assessment:		
Final product (insect model)		
Key Points:		
- Students continue developing, refining, and completing their “Unacknowledged Maps” and Mapmaker’s Statements. - Students use feedback from peers and teachers to clarify their message and strengthen their symbolism. - Students self-assess progress using the project rubric and reflect on how their maps represent acknowledgment and legacy. - Students prepare their projects for submission to the BreakFree national competition.		
Component:	Teacher & Student Actions	Materials
Do Now	Do Now: What’s your goal for today’s work session?	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal Slides
Independent Practice	Students will work independently on their insect model	Pencils, paper, colored pencils, other allowed materials
Closing	- Exit Ticket: Before you go, answer one of the following questions: - What part of your map are you most excited about so far? - What’s one challenge you faced today—and how did you handle it? - What’s one thing you learned today that you didn’t know before? - What’s your next step for tomorrow?	Handouts or blank piece of paper, or journal
Differentiation Considerations:		
- Provide individualized feedback checkpoints throughout the work sessions. - Offer printed rubrics so students can self-assess progress.		

- Allow flexible pacing – some students may need an extra session for revision.
- Provide access to alternate materials (markers, collage supplies, digital tools).
- Support verbal reflection for students who struggle with writing.

Standard(s):

- CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.WHST.6-8.5 – Develop and strengthen writing by planning, revising, editing, and rewriting.
- D2.His.16.6-8 – Organize applicable evidence into a coherent argument about the past.
- CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.SL.8.4 – Present claims and findings with clear evidence and organization.